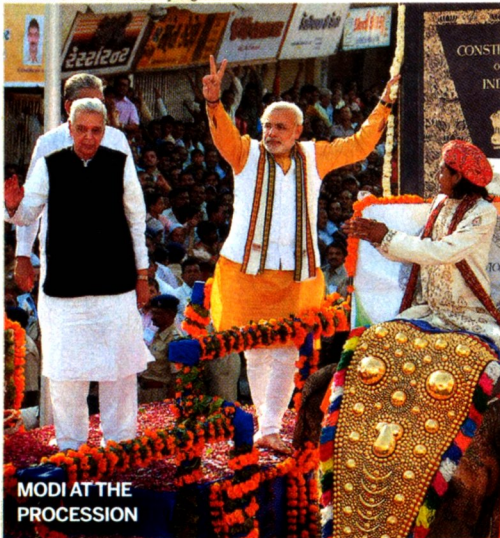


GUJARAT | By The Book

SHAILESH RAVAL/www.indiatodayimages.com



MODI AT THE PROCESSION

This was a yatra with a political difference. Called the Pothi Yatra, it was meant to replicate the old practice of people carrying epics like the Ramayana and Mahabharata on their heads through villages and towns. The state Government launched a Pothi Yatra with the Indian Constitution as the centre of attention and respect. Instead of holy books, it was the Constitution that was placed in a saddle on an elephant during Republic Day celebrations in Surendranagar, Saurashtra. Chief Minister Narendra Modi declared the Constitution to be "a link between ancient and modern India". The yatra's stated purpose was to revive GenNext's respect and knowledge of the Constitution. It certainly pulled in the crowds.

by Uday Mahurkar

MUMBAI | Lost Worlds

India has lost a slice of history. Almost 150 antique maps, some from the 18th century, have gone missing from the Asiatic Society of Mumbai. The terrifying discovery was made during the first extensive survey and restoration process initiated by the society. B. Arunachalam, who heads the project, says the missing documents could have been stolen, misplaced or eaten by termites. "We can't be sure till the survey is complete." Now the society needs both preservation and hunt.

by Nishat Bari

MUMBAI | Whirly Bid

HELIPADS AT BEST'S WELL-KNOWN BUS DEPOTS AIM TO TAKE THE STING OUT OF MUMBAI'S TRAFFIC MESS.

If the Brihanmumbai Electricity Supply and Transport Undertaking (BEST) has its way, helicopters could soon be taking off from bus depots in Mumbai. It is planning to let Global Flying Club, a helicopter charter service, use four bus depots as helipads. Apart from offering joyrides, the service aims at enhancing intra-city connectivity and making tourist spots more accessible. Backbay has been chosen for VIP movements and its proximity to South Mumbai; Dharavi because it lies close to the business hub of Bandra-Kurla complex; Worli for its concentration of offices; and Gorai for joyrides from Vipassana and EsselWorld to Worli.

by Harsha Bhat

TECHNOLOGY WILL NOW MAKE **THE TIRUPATI TEMPLE** MORE PILGRIM-FRIENDLY.

HYDERABAD | Science of Religion

The Tirumala temple is India's richest and could well qualify as one of the busiest too. Naturally, waiting time for *darshan* runs into several hours. To tackle this queue, the temple's managerial body, the Tirumala Tirupati Devasthanam (TTD), has decided to take recourse to technology and introduce a barcode-printed photo system. Devotees waiting for a sight of the gods will now be given a card with their photo printed on it and the card will also contain their darshan timings. Instead of waiting endlessly for hours, pilgrims will now enter the Vaikuntam Queue Complex (vqc) only an hour before the assigned time. "This obviates the need for devotees to stay in the vqc during nights," says TTD Executive Officer IYR Krishna Rao. The use of technology applies in other areas of the temple complex too. A state-of-the-art laddu-making machine is now in operation to meet the ever-increasing demand.

by Amarnath K. Menon

PILGRIMS WAITING FOR DARSHAN

